



OCTOBER – PROTECTING THE COLONY FOR WINTER

October is often the month when the beekeeping year begins to feel noticeably different.

The frantic pace of spring and summer has gone.

Swarm control has finished.

Honey harvesting is largely complete.

Many colonies are now settling into the rhythm of winter survival.

The beekeeper's role changes too.

For much of the year we actively manage colonies.

In October we increasingly protect them.

The focus is no longer on expansion or honey production.

The focus is on helping healthy colonies remain healthy until spring arrives.

WEATHER, TEMPERATURE & SEASONAL CHANGE

October weather in the UK can vary enormously.

Some days still feel surprisingly mild, while others bring heavy rain, strong winds and the first signs of winter.

Daylight hours continue to shorten rapidly.

Night temperatures often fall significantly.

Flying opportunities become increasingly limited.

Forage sources continue to decline.

The bees recognise these changes immediately.

Brood production slows further.

The colony begins forming tighter clusters during cooler periods.

Activity around the hive entrance becomes noticeably reduced compared to summer.

REALITY CHECK: A quiet hive in October is usually a normal hive. The colony is conserving energy rather than expanding.



WHAT YOUR BEES ARE DOING

The colony is now focused almost entirely on survival.

Worker bees are protecting stores, caring for the final brood of the season and preparing for prolonged periods of poor weather.

Winter bees should already be present within the colony.

These bees are very different from summer bees.

They are designed to survive for months rather than weeks.

The colony depends upon them.

Every decision made during late summer and early autumn now begins to show its results.

Strong colonies generally appear calm, organised and purposeful.

Weak colonies often become increasingly obvious.

THE IMPORTANCE OF WINTER STORES

October is not the time to assume everything is fine.

Every colony should still be assessed carefully for food reserves.

Many experienced beekeepers continue hefting their hives throughout autumn.

A hive that feels surprisingly light in October deserves attention.

Colonies consume stores throughout winter, even when they appear inactive.

The objective is simple:

Ensure the bees never run out of food.

PRACTICAL RULE: Too much food rarely causes a problem. Too little food frequently does.

WHEN FONDANT BECOMES IMPORTANT

By October, temperatures may become unsuitable for large-scale syrup feeding.

This is where fondant begins to play a more important role.

Fondant is not necessarily replacing winter stores.

It is providing security.

Many beekeepers keep fondant ready long before it is needed.



If a colony begins to feel light during late autumn or winter, the feed is immediately available.

Preparation is often more valuable than reacting after a problem develops.

INSULATION AND CONDENSATION

One of the biggest winter threats is not cold.

It is damp.

Honey bees can tolerate surprisingly low temperatures when dry.

They struggle far more with persistent moisture.

Condensation develops when warm air from the cluster meets cold surfaces within the hive.

If enough moisture accumulates, water can drip back onto the bees.

For this reason, many beekeepers focus on improving roof insulation during October.

The aim is not to create a heated hive.

The aim is to reduce moisture problems.

REALITY CHECK: Cold bees can survive, wet bees often cannot.

MOUSE GUARDS AND AUTUMN PESTS

As temperatures fall, mice begin searching for warm, sheltered locations.

A beehive can provide exactly what they need.

A single mouse entering a hive may create significant disruption during winter.

October is therefore an ideal time to ensure mouse guards are fitted securely.

While wasp pressure is often reducing, weaker colonies may still be vulnerable to robbing.

Entrances should remain appropriate for colony strength.

Good hive security remains important throughout autumn.



PROTECTING HIVES FROM STORMS

October often marks the beginning of stronger autumn weather.

Roofs, straps and hive stands should all be checked carefully.

A small issue that seems insignificant now can become a major problem during a winter storm.

Check:

- Hive straps
- Roof condition
- Hive stands
- Stability of stacks
- Drainage around the apiary

Every hive should be capable of surviving several months of poor weather without requiring emergency intervention.

REDUCING INSPECTIONS

October is not a month for routine full inspections.

Opening hives unnecessarily risks chilling brood and disturbing the colony.

The best beekeepers often spend more time observing than inspecting during autumn.

Useful checks include:

- Entrance activity
- Hive weight
- Signs of robbing
- Condition of equipment
- Weather damage

Most information can be gathered without dismantling the colony.

The bees benefit from stability.



CLEANING AND ORGANISING EQUIPMENT

As hive activity reduces, attention often turns towards equipment.

October is one of the best months for:

- Cleaning spare boxes
- Organising frames
- Assessing comb replacement needs
- Cleaning tools
- Storing feeders
- Preparing equipment for next year

These tasks are rarely exciting.

They are often extremely valuable.

A well-organised beekeeper usually enjoys a much easier spring.

PLANNING FOR NEXT SEASON

October also provides an opportunity to reflect.

Which colonies performed best?

Which queens would you like to breed from?

What equipment will be needed next year?

Are there improvements that could be made to the apiary?

Many successful seasons begin with planning carried out during autumn.

OCTOBER TAKEAWAY

October is the month when active management gives way to protection.

The bees have largely completed their preparations.

The beekeeper's role is now to remove unnecessary risks.

Adequate stores.

Dry conditions.

Good ventilation.

Protection from pests.



BeezKnees – October Apiary Master Guide

October apiary master guide for cool, temperate UK climate

www.beezknees.co.uk

Protection from weather.

If those foundations are in place, the colony can focus on what it does best.

Surviving winter.

REALITY CHECK: The best thing a beekeeper can often do in October is prepare thoroughly, then leave the bees in peace.